UBER INDIA | PRODUCT RESEARCH

The pickup gap: what goes wrong between booking and boarding

Market research, evidence from public voices, and three research-led ideas for a more reliable pickup.

46%

of Bengaluru Uber users in a LocalCircles survey reported a driver cancelling a ride

Aug 2024, as reported by Business Today. Ola: 62%.

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Research goal: understand the window between booking and boarding

1 Booking confirmed | 2 Driver en route | 3 Driver arrives | 4 Finding each other | 5 Boarding

Out of scope: music, AC, cleanliness, safety awareness and pricing. They are real, but they are not this window.

RESEARCH GOAL

Understand why the minutes between confirmation and boarding fail in crowded places, for riders and for drivers, before proposing any solution.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A rider boards soon after the driver arrives, with no cancellation and no call to find each other.

KEY QUESTIONS

Tell me about the last time a pickup went wrong before you got in.

Walk me through it from confirming to sitting in the car.

Where were you standing, and how did you choose?

What did you do when you could not see the driver?

How do you handle this at malls and airports now?

Drivers: your last rider you could not find: what did the pin show?

METHOD AND LIMITS

Evidence: dated public accounts from Reddit, X, a forum and news reports, 3 surveys, Uber's own pages, 2 regulations, and 1 quote from my earlier driver interviews.

Posts from Reddit and X are cited as reported by news outlets.

Older posts carry their year. No Uber internal data.

The questions on the left guide the next 10 interviews (slide 10).

India ride-hailing is a $16.5B market, and Uber holds about 40% of rides

TAM: ABOUT $16.5B

India taxi market $23.88B in 2025 (IMARC) x 69.2% ride hailing.

SAM: ABOUT $6.6B

Uber holds about 40% of all rides and 45% of cab rides (Outlook Business, Feb 2026). Takes share of rides equals share of value.

DEMAND SIGNAL

LocalCircles, Bengaluru, about 3,500 frequent users, Aug 2024: 85% of Uber customers met at least one issue in 12 months. 46% reported a driver cancelling.

WHERE PICKUP IS HARDEST: FOUR SEGMENTS

Airports

About 1.3 lakh passengers a day at Bengaluru (Jan 2026). Pickups moved to zone P4, about 700 m from Arrivals. Maharashtra fines airport cancellations at 50% of fare.

Malls and venues

Uber named 14 Mumbai pickup venues in 2017, among them the airport, malls and stations, so drivers could find riders in public places.

Residential and office complexes

A 2017 forum post about Ola: the driver “kept waiting on the main road even though the pick-up location was hardly 100 m away”.

Streets at peak hours

A Bengaluru rider saw a 71-minute wait for an Uber auto in May 2023, then posted “Driver Cancelled after 1 min. Sad ending.”

Not yet sized: trips per segment x failed-pickup rate x cost of a failed pickup. Uber holds all three numbers; none is public.

Sources: IMARC; Outlook Business 27 Feb 2026; Business Today 23 Aug 2024; Deccan Herald (Dec 2025, Jan 2026, Aug 2024); Uber 2017; Team-BHP 2017; Curly Tales.

Riders patch the gap with calls and second apps, and Uber's fixes cover only part of it

WHAT RIDERS DO TODAY

Call or text the driver (slides 6 and 7).

Guide the driver by phone: “I once spent 15 minutes in an unfamiliar city trying to guide the driver on phone.” (Team-BHP, 2017)

Book two apps and expect one to cancel (a Bengaluru venture capitalist, BuzzFeed News).

Walk to a different zone, as at Bengaluru airport.

Switch: “If new apps can address these issues, many of us would gladly switch.” (Sushma K, Deccan Herald, 25 Aug 2024)

WHAT UBER ALREADY HAS

Edit pickup (2017)	Move the pin after booking.	Once, inside the gray circle, not on UberPool.
uberVENUES (2017)	Pick from set points at 14 Mumbai venues.	Mumbai list from 2017. No live status.
Wait-time charge (2017)	Free for 5 minutes, then ₹1.5 a minute on uberGO and uberX.	Charges the rider. Mumbai in the post I found.
Directions to pickup	Walking steps in the app at airports.	Uber says general maps may not match the meeting point.

A RIVAL HAS ALREADY MOVED

Rapido, using Google Maps' Addresses and Location Context in a two-city proof of concept: calls about unclear pickup directions fell from 5% of all calls to under 1%.

THE GAP

Among the tools I found, none gives rider and driver a shared, live view of the gap between arrival and boarding.

Sources: Uber help page and 4 May 2017 India announcement; Uber newsroom May 2017; Uber blog 16 Aug 2017; Uber BLR airport page; Google Maps Platform (Rapido); BuzzFeed News; Team-BHP.

Rules now put a price on a failed pickup, and airports are where it bites

National guidelines, Jul 2025

A rider or driver who cancels without a valid reason pays 10% of the fare, capped at ₹100. Apps must list the acceptable reasons.

Maharashtra rules, Jul 2026

Driver cancels: 10% capped at ₹100, paid to the rider; 50% of fare for airports, stations and hospitals. Driver not at pickup within 10 minutes of the ETA: ₹100 more. Rider cancels: 5% capped at ₹100.

Bengaluru airport, Dec 2025

Pickups moved to zone P4, about 700 m from Arrivals. The airport said it would monitor the system for 30 days.

Data protection rules, Nov 2025

Notice duties phase in over 12 to 18 months. Any live-location or photo request needs a clear notice (my reading).

TRENDS

Rapido has about 50% of rides and Uber about 40% (Outlook Business, 27 Feb 2026).

Uber India's net ride-hailing revenue fell 89% to ₹88 crore in FY25, while gross commissions held at ₹2,604 crore.

Cancellation penalties are moving from a national guideline into state rules.

SO WHAT

Whoever can show who failed in the window, the rider not at the pin or the driver not arriving, avoids unfair penalties. Thin net revenue means ideas must be cheap.

Sources: Entrackr 2 Jul 2025; Outlook Business 31 Jul 2026 and 27 Feb 2026; Business Today 1 Aug 2026; Deccan Herald 25 Dec 2025 and 14 Nov 2025.

Insights 1 to 5: the wait is silent, and each side reads the other badly

	INSIGHT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS	SO WHAT
1	**The only way to check on a driver is a text that can end the ride.** 2 Driver en route	Reddit post, 9 Dec 2025, 4k+ upvotes: rider texts “are you coming” on every trip. Driver: “If it is urgent book another. This is not airplane.” Then cancelled. Rider: “I drop this message to all my trips just get confirmation this didn't go well.!”	**Give riders a status check that costs the driver nothing.**
2	**Drivers and riders disagree on who guides whom.** 4 Finding each other	X post, 26 Aug 2023: a Bengaluru rider asked her driver to come to her pickup spot. His reply: “Location please, I don't need guidance.”	**Carry location context in the app so neither has to explain.**
3	**Phoning to find the pickup became a routine.** 4 Finding each other	Team-BHP, 2017 (Ola): “they always call for guidance to reach the pick-up location. Always. The standard response is that GPS is not working.” On Uber: “Taxi arrived near to my location, but keep on changing position, so i couldnt locate it physically.”	**The 2023 and 2025 posts show the same pattern, so it is structural.**
4	**At airports, where to stand is set by rule, and rules change.** 1 Booking confirmed	Bengaluru moved pickups to zone P4, about 700 m from Arrivals. Petitioner Hareesh Amjuri: “I couldn't find P4 on any of the pickup lane numbers.” (Deccan Herald, 25 Dec 2025.) Uber's Delhi airport guide takes four walking steps (Oct 2019).	**Venue-specific stand points with photos beat a generic pin.**
5	**Reaching the zone does not mean a car is there.** 3 Driver arrives	Deccan Herald, 7 Jan 2026: one passenger walked to P4 and found no drivers waiting; another waited 40 to 50 minutes (an Ola cab). The airport's average that Monday was 20 minutes. Passenger Nabeela Sheikh said the rules had “the exact opposite” effect.	**Show the driver's live position and expected wait, not just a pin.**

Sources: Deccan Herald 9 Dec 2025 (Reddit post as reported), 25 Dec 2025, 7 Jan 2026; Business Today 26 Aug 2023; Team-BHP 2017; Uber Delhi airport guide 14 Oct 2019.

Insights 6 to 10: cancellations dominate, and not all are about finding the rider

	INSIGHT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS	SO WHAT
6	**Cancellation is the most common failure in the window.** 2 Driver en route	LocalCircles, Bengaluru, Aug 2024: 46% of Uber users reported “driver cancelled ride” (Ola 62%). Mumbai Grahak Panchayat, May 2023, n=1,629: 73.4% named drivers cancelling after booking their biggest difficulty.	**Log every cancellation with a reason, or fixes miss the cause.**
7	**Some failures are not about finding the rider: the driver chose not to come.** 2 Driver en route	BuzzFeed News (undated page), Delhi driver Balwant Sahay: “I can't drive 10 miles to pick up someone only to drop them 2 miles away.” Rider Sanjana Vijayshankar after six cancellations in a day: “Even dates haven't ghosted me this bad.”	**A better pin cannot fix this. Show the driver the trip's value earlier.**
8	**Uber's own fixes help the rider once, and only on the pin.** 1 Booking confirmed	Uber, 4 May 2017: “Pick-ups are one of the hardest parts of the experience to get right.” Edit pickup works once and only inside the gray circle. Uber says wrong pins often end in a call and a cancelled ride.	**Extend help to the live window and to the driver's side.**
9	**Money changes pickup behavior, but Uber's version is thin.** 3 Driver arrives	My own interview, Bangalore driver (Tamil, translated): “The waiting time charge feature, the customer got really cautious on where they have to be and it become smooth experience.” Uber's 2017 Mumbai charge starts after 5 free minutes.	**Incentives exist for riders; drivers' lateness is now fined in Maharashtra.**
10	**Better location data cuts the calls.** 4 Finding each other	Rapido, two-city proof of concept with Google Maps' Addresses and Location Context: calls about unclear pickup directions fell from 5% of all calls to under 1%. Captain location visibility rose from 60% to 95%.	**Data can fix a large slice, and a rival can copy it, so speed matters.**

Sources: Business Today 23 Aug 2024; Governance Now (May 2023); BuzzFeed News; Uber 2017 and help page; FoneArena; Google Maps Platform; my own interview.

Strategy: manage the window as one journey, and split ‘cannot find’ from ‘will not come’

1 Measure the window as one journey

Define pickup success: the rider boards soon after arrival, with no cancellation and no call. Track calls, cancellation reasons and time to board before building features.

Evidence: 6, 10. Trade-off: instrumentation comes first, so the first win is slower.

2 Treat two failure types separately

‘Cannot find’ needs information and venue context. ‘Will not come’ needs incentives and earlier clarity for the driver.

Evidence: 2, 3, 4, 7, 9. Trade-off: two owners, maps and venues versus marketplace and pricing.

3 Start where rules and pain meet: airports, then big venues

Maharashtra fines airport cancellations at 50% of fare and Bengaluru's zone is 700 m away.

Evidence: 4, 5. Trade-off: airport authorities set the rules, so start with content Uber controls.

4 Keep it cheap and free for riders

Rapido holds about 50% of rides, riders say they would switch, and Uber's net ride-hailing revenue is thin. No new fee for pickup help.

Guardrail: booking conversion and ETA must not worsen.

Three research-led ideas, each with a metric, a guardrail and a first test

Venue pickup cards

Insights 4, 5, 10

At airports and big venues, show the exact stand point with a photo, walking time and an ‘I'm here’ check-in. Start with Bengaluru's P4 and Delhi.

METRIC

Time from driver arrival to boarding; pickup calls per trip.

GUARDRAIL

Booking conversion and ETA.

FIRST TEST

Two venues, four weeks, compare against matched venues.

Two-tap window messages

Insights 1, 2, 3

One shared panel with preset messages in each person's language: ‘I'm at the pin’, ‘2 minutes late’, ‘Where are you?’, ‘At the gate’, ‘Can't see you, send a photo’.

METRIC

Share of trips with a voice call in the window. Reference: Rapido went from 5% to under 1%.

GUARDRAIL

Driver acceptance rate.

FIRST TEST

Painted door: show the buttons to 5% of riders in two cities and count taps before building translation.

Can’t-find-rider proof flow

Insights 6, 7, 9

The driver taps ‘can’t find rider’. The app asks the rider to share live location or a photo for 60 seconds and logs a reason code, as the national guidelines require reasons.

METRIC

Share of cancellations with a reason; disputes per 1,000 cancellations.

GUARDRAIL

Rider complaints about unfair no-show fees.

FIRST TEST

One city in shadow mode for four weeks: log only, apply no penalties.

Next: ten anchored interviews, Uber's own numbers, and clear tests of my view

Next 10 interviews

- 6 riders: 2 airport arrivals, 2 mall visitors, 2 from apartments or offices.
- 4 drivers: 2 airport-heavy, 2 city.
- Every question anchored to the window, using the guide on slide 2.
- If a participant drifts to AC or music, note it and steer back.
- Keep consent photos or message screenshots as proof.

What I cannot see from outside

- Pickup success rate and time to board by venue.
- Cancellations by reason, and by driver or rider.
- Trips from airports, malls and complexes.
- Public posts skew to angry users, and several are from 2017 or 2023.
- Surveys cover Bengaluru users, with sample sizes not always stated.

What would change my mind

- If most cancellations in Uber's data are ‘will not come’, shift effort from venue cards to idea 3.
- If calls in venues are already under 1% of calls, drop idea 2 there.
- If the first venue test lifts no boarding times in four weeks, stop and rethink the card.
- If riders read the check-in as an extra task, cut it.

Sources

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Uber help: edit pickup

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Business Today, 1 Aug 2026: Maharashtra penalties

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Outlook Business, 27 Feb 2026: Uber India

Also used: one quote from my own earlier interviews with Bangalore drivers (Tamil, translated).